

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

HOUSE CONCURRENT RESOLUTION NO. 26

BY RESOURCES AND CONSERVATION COMMITTEE

A CONCURRENT RESOLUTION

STATING FINDINGS OF THE LEGISLATURE AND SUPPORTING WILDLIFE CROSSINGS.

Be It Resolved by the Legislature of the State of Idaho:

WHEREAS, Idaho is home to abundant populations of big game species, including mule deer, elk, and pronghorn, that require intact, long-distance seasonal migrations to access critical habitat for survival; and

WHEREAS, more than 50 big game migration corridors have been mapped across the state, demonstrating that landscape connectivity is vital to Idaho's wildlife and outdoor heritage; and

WHEREAS, preserving and promoting big game migration corridors contributes to Idaho's robust economy and outdoor traditions by promoting healthy wildlife populations that support hunting, outfitting, and other outdoor recreation industries; and

WHEREAS, significant numbers of mule deer, elk, and pronghorn crossing Idaho's highways pose a danger to both wildlife and humans, leading to elevated rates of wildlife-vehicle collisions that result in preventable mortality for both wildlife and humans; and

WHEREAS, each year, hundreds of wildlife-vehicle collisions endanger human lives and cause millions of dollars in property damage and insurance costs; and

WHEREAS, wildlife-vehicle collisions pose a clear risk to public safety, but such risk may be mitigated by certain infrastructure projects; and

WHEREAS, where appropriate and supported by the local community, strategic investments in wildlife crossings, such as overpasses, underpasses, and related fencing, have proven highly effective in reducing wildlife-vehicle collisions by over 80% while maintaining the integrity of migration corridors, enabling wildlife to travel between summer and winter ranges; and

WHEREAS, multiple infrastructure projects in Idaho facilitating the safe movement of wildlife across roadways, including the first wildlife overpass constructed in the state, the Cervidae Peak Wildlife Overpass over Highway 21, have shown significant benefits to wildlife movement and to reductions in wildlife-vehicle collisions, demonstrating the effectiveness of crossing structures and providing a basis of success to build on elsewhere; and

WHEREAS, engaging with local communities and providing affected stakeholders with relevant information regarding associated infrastructure projects for facilitating wildlife movement across highways is an important component of implementing initiatives to conserve intact migration corridors in Idaho; and

WHEREAS, a proactive approach to promoting intact wildlife migration corridors, including coordination with state agencies and local commu-

1 nities, will contribute to the long-term viability of Idaho's wildlife
2 resources and enhance public safety.

3 NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED by the members of the Second Regular Ses-
4 sion of the Sixty-eighth Idaho Legislature, the House of Representatives and
5 the Senate concurring therein, that the Legislature strongly supports the
6 advancement of public safety and conservation of Idaho's big game migration
7 corridors through the development and implementation of wildlife crossings
8 where appropriate and supported by local communities.

9 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Legislature encourages state and local
10 governments to adopt policies that preserve and promote landscape connec-
11 tivity and migration corridors, to promote road safety, and to collaborate
12 with local communities, private stakeholders, and other partners to iden-
13 tify priority sites for potential wildlife crossings and to invest in sci-
14 ence-based solutions that benefit both wildlife and Idaho citizens.

15 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that copies of this resolution be transmitted to
16 the congressional delegation representing the State of Idaho in the Congress
17 of the United States, the Governor of the State of Idaho, the Director of the
18 Idaho Department of Fish and Game, and the Director of the Idaho Transporta-
19 tion Department.